

H. F. MISSELWITZ, Gen. Agt.,
Ryan Bldg., Leavenworth, Kan.

STRANGE ISLANDS NEAR THE CALIFORNIA COAST

ONCE THE HOME OF A RACE NOW
EXTINCT.

EXPEDITION FITTING OUT TO EX-
PLORE THE ST. NICHOLAS ISL-
ANDS — CURIOUS TALES TOLD
OF THE LONELY LAND—NUM-
EROUS SKULLS AND HUMAN
BONES INDICATE A MIGHTY
BATTLE BETWEEN SAVAGE
TRIBES.

San Francisco, Cal., Dec. 2.—An ex-
pedition of scientific students has been
made up in Los Angeles and Pasadena
to explore thoroughly the Channel Isl-
ands off that part of the coast of Cal-
ifornia known as Santa Barbara and
San Buenaventura counties during the
next six months.

The party is to be sustained by Stan-

Next are the Channel Islands. The party is to be sustained by Stanford university largely, and to a less extent by several denominational colleges in southern California. Anthropological and archaeological students, who have spent several weeks each on these islands, say they are one of the very richest fields for work in that department of knowledge on the Pacific coast. The Channel Islands constitute California's only archipelago, with the possible exception of the rocky and scanty Farallone Islands. They have been objects of romance, legends, curiosity and mystery for a generation or more.

Notwithstanding all the islands are within eighty-two miles of California's shore they are solitary and unfrequented, and years roll by with visits to them of less than fifty people annually. Each island has its own particular strange, uncanny traditions of the tribes of red men, and each has countless traces of an occupation by thousands and thousands of Indians. When Juan Rodriguez Cabrillo, the Portuguese navigator, sailed up the coast of California in 1542, he stopped for a day or two at each of the Channel Islands and his records bear testimony that on the islands of Santa Barbara, Catalina, Clemente and St. Nicholas there were "a vigorous and lusty race of natives who thronged the shores of the little bays and headlands" and gazed in mute wonder at the white-sailed ships of the navigators. Today the islands

mute wonder at the white-sailed ships of the navigators. Today the islands stand as they did over 250 years ago, but the natives are only a memory, represented by immense quantities of stone implements, barrels of fine wampum and literally cartloads of human bones.

EIGHTY MILES FROM COAST.

St. Nicholas island lies eighty miles immediately opposite the little city of San Buenaventura recently called by the more modern and easy name of Ventura and is the most interesting of all the channel islands from many points of view. As far back as the memory of any person in southern California runs hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillsides. Strange utensils of serpentine sandstone and steatite are found there among the human bones and the island and its erstwhile inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the Franciscan padres in the Santa Barbara mission, learning that there were but sixteen of the strange and almost extinct Indian race then living there, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child and one of the frequent storms of the channel springing up, the sloop was driven away without her. The sloop went on the rocks of Point Conception and all were lost. Sixteen years later Capt. George Nid-

Eighteen years later, Capt. George Nid-
ewar and two men went from the coast
on a sloop to hunt otter off St. Nich-
olas. On landing they were like Crusoe,
astonished to discover human foot-
prints in the sand. They saw no one
however, and a storm compelled them
to put to sea. It was two years there-
after that the adventurous captain,
revolving in his mind the sight of the
footprints in the uncanny island, de-
termined to go and discover and bring
over the lonely woman of whom he had
vaguely heard. Men accompanied him
and at length they saw on the surf-
beaten shore, a woman with long,
laxny hair, dressed in a queer garb of
colored bird skins and scraping with
a bone knife the blubber from a seal.

They surrounded and approached her
stealthily, and although suddenly con-
fronted she did not appear in the least
afraid but smiled, and then falling on
her knees, prayed to the sun. The
wild woman offered no objection when
by signs she was made to understand
she was to go with them to the boat.

LAST OF HER RACE.

They reached Santa Barbara across
the rough sea, and the first thing the
Indian woman saw was a man riding
a horse. She had never seen nor heard
of any object like it, and thought the
man and horse were one, and she knelt
on the shore and offered her devotions
to it. Two weeks afterward the last
inhabitant of the rock-ribbed, tempest-

toasted St. Nicholas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, furnished by her rescuers, and the curtain fell on her race forever. The woman, known as the "Lone Woman of St. Nicholas" has been the subject of a score of romances and poems.

St. Nicholas is ten miles long and four miles wide at the widest point. Its topography shows a nearly level plateau, with an elevation of 800 to 1,000 feet. Two-thirds of the surface is covered with drifting sand, and the remainder grows a species of nutritious grass and moss, on which a thousand sheep find pasture. Several springs have been discovered, but their water is slightly brackish. Of late years the island is rarely visited, except by sheep shearers and shell gatherers, who make annual trips in schooners, fishing smacks or Chinese junks.

The only safe landing ground at St. Nicholas is at Coral harbor, a pretty cove formed by two sandstone arms thrust out from the main barrier of the shore. The entrance is but six or seven yards across, and the water within is as placid as a lake and sufficiently deep to float a vessel of twenty tons burden. On the bleak, silvery strip of beach immense white pelicans are to be seen at almost any season of the

be seen at almost any season of the year promenading with stately dignity. On the approach of the dingy they spread their heavy pointed wings and vanish over the rocks. Farther up the slope of the beach there is a dilapidated shearing shed, and a weather-worn shanty belonging to Chinese shell gatherers. Nothing more desolate than the general appearance of the island can well be imagined.

DESOLATION IS COMPLETE.

As far as the eye can trace there are barren levels with innumerable circular depressions, showing where primitive dwellings once stood. Not a vestige remains of the materials used in the construction of these rancherias. Hundreds of shell mounds are scattered about, and are found to consist of astonishing numbers of mollusks, the bones of every species of fish found in the channel, skeletons of seals, sea otter, the island fox and various aquatic birds. Without question these animals were used for food by the tribe that once thronged these boundaries. There are also numerous canine skeletons, several of which indicated a species of bull terrier. Judging from the immense quantities of dead land mollusks everywhere, there must have been a time when the island supported a luxuriant vegetation. Of all this

been a time when the island supported a luxuriant vegetation. Of all this verdure nothing is seen today but a few stunted thorn bushes, and now and then a cactus forlornly reaching its grotesque arms out of the interminable sweeps of sand.

An examination of some of the mounds discloses all sorts of curious utensils—stone cooking pots, ollas, mortars, pestles, drills, bone needles and fish hooks, shell beads, charm stones, pipes, cups and a few arrowheads, spear points and swords made of bone. The absence of many weapons proves the peaceful attributes of the islanders. Small imitation of boats and fish carved from crystallized talc and serpentine also shows a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture. In many places conical piles of small black pebbles contrasts oddly with the white sand. In some instances these pebbles are packed in abalone shells. No trace is seen of the "brush pens" in which a woman for years found her only shelter from the cutting winds and sand. Nature, ever unmindful of the individual, long since merged the superhuman efforts of this courageous life into the universal fate of an entire race. Indeed, every foot of this strange island is eloquent of the extinction of almost unheard-of people.

A tale along the west coast of St.

unlearned people.

A trip along the west coast of St. Nicholas Island over a vast extent of shell mounds was one to wondering how it was possible for a limited population to consume such prodigious numbers of mollusks. In fact, the infinite variety of mollusca on St. Nicholas is said by biologists not to be exceeded by any other known region of equal area. The shore line is of coarse sandstone, burrowed by the pounding surf into fantastic alcoves, bridges, columns and caves. Sometimes these savage cuts form rude effigies bearing a surprising likeness to living creatures. One of the most conspicuous is the exact counterpart of the neck, the breast and body of a bird with an alert hooded head. This piece of nature's sculpturing must be forty feet long, and beheld from a distance, looks as perfect as if fashioned by men. There are hundreds of photographs of this freak of nature sold all over California.

Going westward from this gnawed, surf-lashed wall the ground makes a gentle descent to a wide mesa, terminating in a steep escarpment. The atmosphere from this elevation is so delicately clear that the eye can readily distinguish the peaked tops of all the channel islands, several of them being forty miles away. Immediately at our feet there stretches away a dreary des-

ert of stupendous barrenness. A singular characteristic of the place were heaps of the bones of whales, their arrangement and packing so systematically correct as to have withstood a century's sweep of winds over this exposed point. But one human skeleton has been found there, its bleached, dismembered aspect in keeping with the driven desolation of the spot. The merciless blast had piled the sand dunes all about, but spread no kindly drift over this rough "sketch of man." All around are the casts of roots of trees in the shifting sand, ranging all the way in size from coarse fibre to several inches in diameter. These semi-petrifications are intact, the wind having swept them clean of the loose earth. They yield a metallic ring when tapped with a rock or shell. A still more remarkable feature of this desert is a stone forest, the broken columns composed of indurated sand.

AN ANCIENT BATTLEFIELD.

The most gruesome of all the sights on this strange island is to be seen on the broad plateau south of the Chinese camp at Coral harbor. Here acres of the naked sand are littered with hundreds of disjointed skeletons, and present the most reckless illustration of the "ground plan" of humanity that imagination can picture. Measurements

of the "ground plan" of humanity that imagination can picture. Measurements have been made by several scientists of the thigh, leg and arm bones, and literally bushels of skulls and other parts of the human frame have been brought to Los Angeles from St. Nicholas islands for investigation. The general opinion is that the Indian race that swarmed over the island was much larger than any civilized race of today and that some of the men must have been seven feet three inches tall. The skulls of this extinct tribe often measure several inches more than some of other large skulls of today. Many skulls found lying about on the island show that their possessors must have suffered death from a club or blunt battle ax. No one has ever yet found a skull on St. Nicholas that shows marks of a bullet. There are many collar bones and shoulder blades broken and crushed so it is evident their owner was killed by some instrument as a war club or a bowdier. Scientists say that the favorite weapon in warfare with the Aleutian savage tribes a century and more ago was a club or bludgeon and this fact fits with the stray traditions that the Aleutians came down and completely destroyed the people on Channel islands.
